CHAPTER 18

OUT OF SYNC

Summer 2005

ENGLAND vs AUSTRALIA

England beat Australia 2-1 in the series

Where I once felt like I was going to walk through the world almost completely unnoticed, occasionally kicking a jumper down to fine leg in a sulk at Burnley, these days my life spills out in a micro-managed, highly policed environment at all waking hours. Drug tests are done with someone waiting in a cubicle and nutritionists monitor and supply everything I eat. On the field too, where I once ran in on complete innate feel, on a wave of subconscious flow, now everything is filmed, monitored, played back on computers, analysed.

Troy Cooley, whom I have worked with since the England academy, is the bowling coach. I really like him – we get on brilliantly. He has me wired up on biomechanics, strapping me head to toe in wired balls, going through my action, filmed on cameras from every conceivable angle. They break it down and play it back in micro-detail, everything slowed down until every step, every impact is measured and enlarged, each imperfection exposed. They discover that as I approach my load and delivery stride, my spine takes on an unusual shape. It appears to morph itself into an S-shaped curve beyond what is considered healthy. It is sent around the staff, pored over and sent back. They decide that it's a real long-term concern for my back. They start to speak to me about the ways I might be able to start affecting the spine to have one curve rather than the double curved S in its stride.